



MONTHLY UPDATE

Sierra Leone: monthly update, July 2026

Edition of 2026-08-13 · 26 systems and instruments tracked, 9 of them not held

Developments recorded from artefacts published between 2026-07-01 and 2026-08-09 – July 2026 carried forward to the date of issue, so the report holds the nightly catch to the day it was cut. Sections follow the status report.

Summary of the month

Two arguments ran side by side in Sierra Leone during July and the first week of August 2026, and both concern the same register. The identity authority and the communications ministry each set out publicly how the country's digital public infrastructure should be sequenced, and the ministry conceded in Parliament that the identity-to-SIM linkage it is relying on to police mobile-money fraud is incomplete. In the same weeks the central bank awarded contracts to re-platform both national payment rails, the government convened a dialogue to make a 2019 statute operable, and the telecoms regulator confirmed it was managing cybersecurity incidents whose scope it did not describe.

Infrastructure

Connectivity

CSquared [added capacity on the 2Africa West submarine system to the West Africa backbone that reaches Sierra Leone](#) on 15 July 2026, giving automated rerouting across physically diverse paths after repeated regional outages.

The health ministry [launched Starlink service at the Julius Maada Bio Paediatric Centre of Excellence on 27 July 2026](#), the first of a stated 300 government health facilities. Neither account of the launch gives the cost, the funder, the procurement route, the contract term, or any data-residency arrangement for public health traffic carried by a foreign satellite operator.

Data Storage

The same 7 August account states the biometric register runs on a Tier III data centre, as reported by the NCRA Director-General ([consultation account](#)).

Cybersecurity

The telecoms regulator ran two public-facing cyber messages in nine days. It [set out a consumer education campaign on online fraud on 28 July](#), stating that the fraudulent links circulating did not originate from the mobile networks and placing the burden on the consumer; on 30 July it [confirmed it was coordinating a response to ongoing cybersecurity incidents affecting digital services](#), naming no affected service, no attribution and no incident count.

Digital public infrastructure

Data Exchange

(narrative not yet written)

Digital Identity and CRVS

Identity took three public positions in four days. MoCTI [convened a national dialogue on digital identity and digital public infrastructure on 5 August](#), describing it as the first of a series and as the beginning of the policy work rather than its result. A private-sector consultation the following day settled two specifications: the register being built on is MOSIP-based, and the credentials envisaged under the Bhutan National Digital Identity and SIGN Foundation partnership are W3C-compliant verifiable credentials. On 7 August the NCRA Director-General told the consultation that [the biometric register already covers about 93% of the population with a unique National Identification Number and a live eKYC platform](#), and that the Authority's own MOSIP pilot is complete but unfunded for full implementation — and warned against parallel identity systems being built alongside it.

In a 4 August ministerial statement responding to the mobile-money fraud surge, the communications minister [conceded the NIN-SIM linkage does not yet cover every subscriber](#).

Digital Payments and Fintech

The Bank of Sierra Leone awarded two contracts on 4 August 2026 to re-platform the national payment rails: [US\\$1,869,000 for real-time gross settlement](#) and [US\\$3,194,615 for automated clearing](#). Neither award names the supplier or the scope, and the procurement authority's award register returns no rows to automated retrieval.

The same 4 August ministerial statement [disclosed about 390 Orange mobile-money fraud complaints logged in 2026 to date and more than 18,000 police requests for subscriber data answered](#).

Sectoral management information systems (HMIS, EMIS, etc.)

(narrative not yet written)

Other GovTech and e-Gov

The National Public Procurement Authority [sent a delegation to Liberia on 6-7 August to study that country's electronic government procurement system](#). No Sierra Leonean platform, procurement decision or timetable follows from it on the record.

Use of satellite data

DSTI announced on 4 August that it is [developing a national base map with the Ministry of Lands, with JICA support and Japanese technical direction, phase one covering Western Area Urban District](#). No cost, timetable, hosting arrangement or data licence is stated.

Governance and regulation

Legislation and regulation

A public-private dialogue on 27-28 July was convened to operationalise the Electronic Transactions Act, in force since December 2019 and never given certification authorities, evidence procedures, dispute mechanisms or penalties. It is to produce a gap analysis, a policy memorandum and an implementation roadmap, with no adoption date for any of the three, and worked to functional equivalence and technological neutrality.

The regulator announced on 30 July that the Subscribers Regulations 2025 will fine operators 25,000 new leones for each unregistered or pre-activated SIM, with a staged disconnection ladder and SIMs matched to National Identification Numbers. The six-month transition is presented as running from that announcement, so the phase-out date is unestablished, and the instrument's own text is not held.

Mobile-money fraud reached Parliament. A legal analysis of 23 July found the National Communications Authority Act 2022 addresses its enforcement powers to licensees only, with no statutory reversal mechanism, no SIM-swap safeguards and no allocation of loss for authorised push payment fraud; a former minister replied on 26 July that the central bank's existing know-your-customer rules are adequate and only enforcement is missing, identifying no provision by instrument or section. The two accounts have not been reconciled.

Strategies, plans and policies

Delivering a ministerial statement on 4 August after MPs demanded an explanation for the surge, the communications minister set out education, institutional strengthening and better investigation. No liability rule, refund duty or operator obligation was proposed.

Artificial intelligence and the technology sector

AI

DSTI reported on 24 July that its deepfake and digital-misinformation campaign, running since May 2026, has reached Freetown, Makeni, Port Loko, Magburaka, Bo, Kenema and Kono, convening paramount chiefs, district officials, security institutions, councils and universities, with participants reporting voice-cloning scams impersonating public figures. Broadcast programming, a national capacity-building workshop and a verification chatbot are announced as the next phase. No budget, funder or completion date is stated, and no legislative or platform-facing instrument accompanies it.

Inclusion and capacity

Training and skills

MoCTI and three other bodies launched a digital skills programme for civil servants on 10 July 2026, with 1,000 places in year one and stated targets of 3,000 medium-term and 5,000 long-term across six areas including artificial intelligence and cybersecurity, aimed at gaps outside Freetown.

The country held its [first academic exhibition dedicated to Digital Public Goods on 27 July](#), where [11 student-built solutions were evaluated against the DPG Standard](#). The curriculum behind it, built with UNICEF, the United Nations University and Limkokwing University, has taught more than 1,100 students and appointed 14 campus champions across four universities.

Finance

New investments

The same statement — [reporting the academic Digital Public Goods exhibition](#) — also gives the Sierra Leone Innovation Investment Fund a target of US\$150m over five years, with no amount raised.

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